



Palma Sola Botanic Park

Field Guide to the Living Collection



BRADENTON, FLORIDA • MANATEE COUNTY

Photographs and observations by park volunteers via iNaturalist

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Native Trees & Large Shrubs

Florida's towering backbone — shade, shelter, and centuries of history



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Coral Bean

Erythrina herbacea

FLORIDA NATIVE

Bare branches erupt each spring with towering spikes of tubular scarlet flowers that hummingbirds fiercely defend. By fall, split pods reveal jewel-bright red seeds — beautiful, and among the most toxic plants in the Southeast. Their erythrina alkaloids are potent enough to have served as rat poison and to have been studied alongside modern anesthetics. Long known to Indigenous peoples, the Cherokee name gave rise to its other name, Cherokee Bean.

SIZE

3–20 ft tall × 2–10 ft wide; spiny

CONDITIONS

Sun to part shade • Drought & very salt tolerant

TOXICITY

Deadly — all parts

EDIBILITY

Not edible

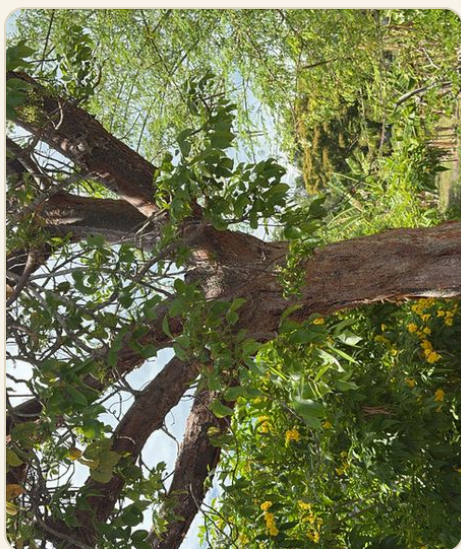


Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Gumbo Limbo

Bursera simaruba

FLORIDA NATIVE

Its coppery, peeling bark earns the nickname "tourist tree" — forever looking sunburned — over smooth, almost waxy olive-green wood beneath. Soft and easily carved, that wood once became carousel horses, while the resin served as varnish, glue, and incense across the Caribbean. Famously hurricane-resistant, it bends in high winds rather than breaking, and a branch pushed into the ground will simply root and grow. Fast-growing and nearly indestructible.

SIZE

To 50 ft (usually 25–40 ft)

CONDITIONS

Full to part sun • Drought & salt tolerant

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

EDIBILITY

Fruit edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Dahoon Holly

Ilex cassine

FLORIDA NATIVE

Bright red berries — mildly toxic to us but a winter lifeline for cedar waxwings, robins, and mockingbirds — glow against glossy evergreen leaves. Every holly on Earth belongs to this single genus. Once common, it is now harder to find in nurseries, thriving in moist coastal woods and swamps from Florida to Cuba. A quiet but vital piece of Florida's winter landscape.

SIZE

20–30 ft

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet • Salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible

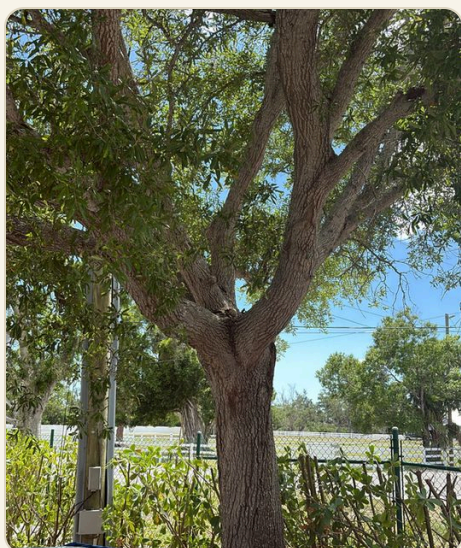


Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Live Oak

Quercus virginiana

FLORIDA NATIVE

Cannonballs reportedly bounced off its dense wood, earning the USS Constitution the name "Old Ironsides." This evergreen Southern icon can shade half an acre beneath a massive, spreading canopy, and its roasted acorns once fed people and wildlife alike. From Virginia to Texas, "live" simply means it never goes bare. A true emblem of strength and endurance.

SIZE

40–80 ft

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten (acorns)

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought & salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Acorns, roasted

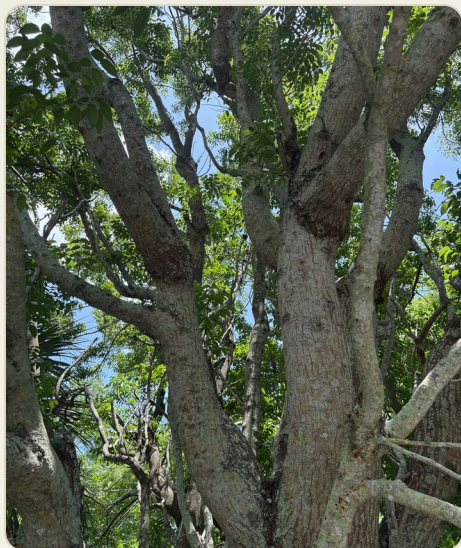


Photo: iNaturalist contributor

West Indian Mahogany

Swietenia mahagoni

FLORIDA NATIVE

Spanish shipbuilders prized its rich reddish-brown wood for hulls that shrugged off cannon fire, shipworms, and rot — long before Chippendale turned it into prized furniture. Overharvesting left it threatened in Florida, so every specimen here is a small act of conservation. Native to the hammocks of the Keys and West Indies. Stately, historic, and increasingly rare.

SIZE

40–80 ft tall, 30–60 ft wide

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

EDIBILITY

Medicinal (bark)



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

American Elm

Ulmus americana

FLORIDA NATIVE

Dutch elm disease, introduced in the 1920s, erased countless graceful elms that once arched over American streets. Florida's own variety still grows wild in floodplain forests, raising cathedral-like canopies. From Canada to the central peninsula, these trees defined whole neighborhoods. A living reminder of both beauty and vulnerability in our landscapes.

SIZE

60–80 ft

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

EDIBILITY

Young leaves edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Wild Lime

Zanthoxylum fagara

FLORIDA NATIVE

Crush a leaf for an instant burst of citrus — this thorny native is a true cousin of oranges and limes. It is the host plant for the giant swallowtail, North America's largest butterfly, whose caterpillars disguise themselves as bird droppings. The fruit delivers a tingling, mouth-numbing kick like Sichuan peppercorns. Common in Central and South Florida hammocks.

SIZE

To 23 ft

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought & salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Fruit (numbing)



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Beautyberry

Callicarpa americana

FLORIDA NATIVE

Each fall it erupts in spectacular clusters of vivid purple berries — one of Florida's showiest native shrubs. USDA researchers found its leaves contain a natural insect repellent rivaling DEET; Indigenous people rubbed them on skin and horses. More than 40 bird species feast on the fruit. A mint-family star of hammocks and forest edges.

SIZE

3–8 ft tall, 3–6 ft wide

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Berries for jelly



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Wax Myrtle

Morella cerifera

FLORIDA NATIVE

Tiny wax-coated berries once fueled colonial candle-making — the source of traditional bayberry candles still burned at the holidays. This adaptable evergreen grows across all of Florida, from wetlands to dunes to forests, and its leaves lend a warm, spicy note to cooking. A true coastal and inland survivor.

SIZE

10–15+ ft tall & wide

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet

EDIBILITY

Leaves as spice

Native Palms & Cycads

Ancient survivors from the age of dinosaurs to the Florida shore



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Buccaneer Palm

Pseudophoenix sargentii

FLORIDA NATIVE

One of America's rarest palms — surveys have found only a handful of wild adults left in the Florida Keys. Its handsome, ringed trunk often swells slightly, like a miniature Royal Palm. Critically endangered in the wild from habitat loss, it is a quiet conservation success in cultivation. Native to extreme southeast Florida and the northern Caribbean.

SIZE

10–25 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Fruit & seeds



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Paurotis Palm

Acoelorrhaphe wrightii

FLORIDA NATIVE

It rises in striking clumps, like natural monuments lifted from Everglades islands. One of the few palms that forms dense groves from a single planting as suckers slowly spread. It is especially dramatic under nighttime lighting. Here it grows at the northern edge of its comfort zone, thanks to the park's mild microclimate.

SIZE

To 30 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Coontie Palm

Zamia integrifolia

FLORIDA NATIVE

A true living fossil — cycads like this grew 300 million years ago, long before the dinosaurs. It is the only food plant for the rare atala butterfly, and both nearly vanished when the plant was overharvested for starch a century ago. Conservation has brought them back together. An ancient Florida survivor.

SIZE

1–5 ft

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought & salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Royal Palm

Roystonea regia

FLORIDA NATIVE

The classic Florida tropical silhouette, crowned by a smooth green crownshaft that sheathes the growing tip like living armor. Healthy trees can live 150 to 200 years, flowering again and again. Native to the rich hammocks of extreme South Florida, plus Mexico, the Caribbean, and Central America. It is Cuba's national tree.

SIZE

Tall; fronds 10–15 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible

Native Wetland & Pond Edge

Life at the water's edge — where land meets the living pond

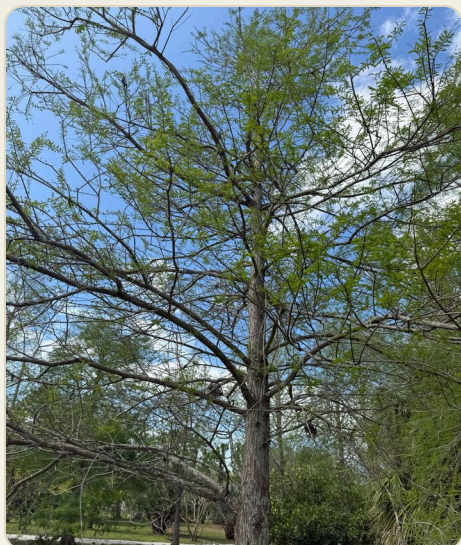


Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Bald Cypress

Taxodium distichum

FLORIDA NATIVE

One of the longest-lived trees on Earth, its annual rings let scientists reconstruct centuries of drought and rainfall. The durable heartwood resists rot even after generations underwater, making it prized for boats and bridges. In winter it drops its needles — "bald" — then leafs out soft and green each spring. A majestic sentinel of Southern swamps.

SIZE

50–70 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Golden Canna

Canna flaccida

FLORIDA NATIVE

Its tough seeds can stay viable for up to 600 years and were once even used as buckshot. Seminoles turned the plant into a wetland multi-tool — for rattles, food wrapping, starch, and jewelry. It is the only canna that tolerates standing water, brightening marshes with sunny yellow blooms across most of Florida.

SIZE

To 6 ft

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet

EDIBILITY

Historic food source



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Muhly Grass

Muhlenbergia capillaris

FLORIDA NATIVE

Come October, airy plumes turn whole stands a breathtaking pink that shifts and glows for weeks. Related grasses have been woven into baskets for centuries in Gullah Geechee tradition. Its fine, hair-like flowers give the species its name. A drought-tough beauty for open, sunny ground.

SIZE

3-4 ft tall & wide

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought & salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Red Mangrove

Rhizophora mangle

FLORIDA NATIVE

Its arching prop roots "breathe" through pores in the bark, letting it thrive in oxygen-starved saltwater mud. A single floating propagule can drift across oceans for over a year before taking root to start a new colony. The reddish wood beneath gray bark helps anchor and protect Florida's coastlines. A living seawall.

SIZE

To 75 ft (usually smaller)

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Alligator Flag

Thalia geniculata

FLORIDA NATIVE

Its tall leaves act as living warning flags — they quiver when an alligator moves through the underwater stems, tipping off anyone nearby. Seminoles made extensive use of its starchy rhizomes. Towering and dramatic, it is a commanding presence in wetlands across the peninsula.

SIZE

6–10 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet

EDIBILITY

Rhizomes (historic)



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Giant Leather Fern

Acrostichum danaeifolium

FLORIDA NATIVE

One of North America's largest ferns, with fronds reaching twelve feet. Thick, waxy leaves shrug off salt spray, and dense colonies make excellent cover for birds and wildlife. Native Americans and early settlers used the fronds for thatch and food storage. A bold, prehistoric-looking anchor for the pond's edge.

SIZE

3–12 ft, spreading

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet • Salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Mauve Indian Mallow

Abutilon hulseanum

FLORIDA NATIVE

Collected for science near Tampa Bay back in the 1840s — a genuine local botanical footnote. Its soft flowers range from mauve-pink to reddish-orange, opening among rounded, velvety leaves. It belongs to the mallow family, a relative of hibiscus, okra, and even the baobab. A gentle, historic presence at the water's edge.

SIZE

To 7 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet

EDIBILITY

Not edible

Native Groundcovers & Wildflowers

Low-growing but never overlooked – color, texture, and wildlife magnets



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Beach Sunflower

Helianthus debilis

FLORIDA NATIVE

Its flower heads track the sun across the sky – the very behavior that named the sunflowers. Tough enough to flourish in pure sand, salt spray, and blazing heat where most plants give up, it sprawls into cheerful golden carpets. A resilient coastal native and a favorite of pollinators.

SIZE

2–6 ft spread

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought & salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Seeds edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Firewheel

Gaillardia pulchella

FLORIDA NATIVE

Vibrant red-and-yellow daisies set roadsides and gardens ablaze all season. Long considered a Florida native, genetic studies hint at Great Plains origins – though it is so well naturalized that botanists still debate the point. Whatever its passport, it is cheerful, tough, and gloriously drought-proof.

SIZE

1–2 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Sunshine Mimosa

Mimosa strigillosa

FLORIDA NATIVE

Brush a leaf and watch it fold shut in a rippling wave — a clever defense called thigmonasty that may startle insects and grazers. Pink powderpuff blooms dot the foliage above. It makes an excellent, walkable groundcover for sunny spots, tough enough to take light foot traffic.

SIZE

6–12 in tall, 2–3 ft spread

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought & salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Scorpion Tail

Heliotropium angiospermum

FLORIDA NATIVE

Its coiled flower spike slowly unfurls fresh white blooms over time, curling like a botanical scorpion's tail to keep pollinators coming back. Elegant and a little unusual, it is widespread through Florida's warmer regions and beyond. A subtle but reliable nectar source for small butterflies.

SIZE

1–3 ft

TOXICITY

Skin & eye irritant

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible

Tropical Specimen Trees

Globe-trotting giants that paint the park in vivid blooms



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Silk Floss Tree

Ceiba speciosa

A botanical Swiss Army knife: silky floss from its pods once stuffed life jackets and upholstery, its light wood became canoes, and its oils served kitchen and industry alike. The bottle-shaped trunk is studded with stout conical spines. Native to South American forests, it brings exotic beauty and utility to the park.

SIZE

30–60 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Edible (parts)



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Jacaranda

Jacaranda mimosifolia

Each spring it unleashes clouds of blue-purple trumpet flowers that can turn whole streets into a living spectacle. One of the most widely planted ornamental trees on Earth, it hails originally from South America's dry valleys. Fern-like foliage gives it a soft, airy silhouette. A beloved global traveler.

SIZE

25–40 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Geiger tree

Cordia sebestena

FLORIDA NATIVE

Named for a colorful Key West sea captain, salvager, and reputed pirate, it bursts with clusters of brilliant orange-red flowers nearly year-round. Native to the Keys, extreme South Florida, and the Caribbean, it is a magnet for butterflies and hummingbirds. Compact, salt-tough, and almost always in bloom.

SIZE

25–30 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought & salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Edible (parts)



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Baobab

Adansonia digitata

Called the "Tree of Life" across African savannas, some baobabs live more than 1,200 years. The spongy trunk stores water — sometimes raided by thirsty elephants — and its leaves, fruit, and seeds provide vital food and medicine. Stout, ancient, and utterly distinctive, it is one of the park's most remarkable specimens.

SIZE

~30–50 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Leaves, fruit, seeds



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Royal Poinciana

Delonix regia

In full bloom the canopy vanishes beneath a sea of fiery red-orange flowers — earning it the nickname Flamboyant. It is the national tree of Puerto Rico, and its true homeland in Madagascar stayed a mystery for centuries. Lacy, fern-like leaves and a broad, umbrella crown make it a showstopper. Spectacular in early summer.

SIZE

30–40 ft

TOXICITY

Toxic — seeds

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Kapok

Ceiba pentandra

Floss from its pods stuffed life jackets and bedding before synthetics took over. In Mayan cosmology this towering giant was the sacred World Tree, linking the underworld, earth, and the heavens. Buttressed and immense, it can soar past 70 feet in cultivation. A true tropical colossus.

SIZE

40–70+ ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Seeds & oil



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Shaving-Brush Tree

Pseudobombax ellipticum var. album

Bare branches suddenly erupt with giant flowers that look just like old-fashioned shaving brushes — one of the park's most dramatic seasonal events. The white-flowered form is especially ethereal in the evening light. A water-storing trunk helps it weather dry spells. Brief, theatrical, and unforgettable.

SIZE

20–40 ft

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible

Tropical & Exotic Palms

Palms from far shores that found a home in Florida's warmth



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Bottle Palm

Hyophorbe lagenicaulis

Its swollen, bottle-shaped trunk makes it one of the most recognizable palms anywhere. Critically endangered on its tiny native island of Mauritius, it is now widely — and safely — grown around the world. Slow and tidy, it rarely outgrows its welcome. A living conservation story in a single, charming silhouette.

SIZE

To 20 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Canary Island Date Palm

Phoenix canariensis

That iconic silhouette lines famous boulevards from Barcelona to California. Healthy specimens develop full, rounded crowns crowded with dozens of arching fronds atop a thick, pineapple-textured trunk. A Mediterranean classic and a stately presence wherever it grows.

SIZE

40-70 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun

EDIBILITY

Fruit (not tasty)



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Traveller's Palm

Ravenala madagascariensis

Its leaf bases catch and store rainwater — a literal lifesaver for thirsty travelers, and the source of its name. The huge fronds fan out in a single dramatic plane, and in its native Madagascar lemurs do much of the pollinating. Striking, architectural, and unmistakable.

SIZE

30–50 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun

EDIBILITY

Seeds edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Screw Pine

Pandanus utilis

Stilt-like prop roots make mature trees look as if they are slowly walking across the landscape. Across the Pacific islands its long leaves are woven into hats, mats, and sails. The large, segmented fruits are fibrous but edible. Bold and sculptural, it is a conversation piece by the water.

SIZE

20–30 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Fruit edible

Flowering Shrubs & Vines

Climbers and bloomers that bring walls and trellises to life



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Tree Crinum

Crinum asiaticum

Massive bulbs — up to 40 pounds — send up spidery white flowers that release a sweet fragrance at night for visiting sphinx moths.

Nicknamed cemetery lilies for their toughness, they often outlive whoever planted them. Bold, strappy, and dramatic, but every part is dangerously poisonous. A handsome Asian introduction common across Florida.

SIZE

3–5 ft

TOXICITY

Deadly — all parts

CONDITIONS

Part shade • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Weeping Bottlebrush

Melaleuca viminalis

Cascading branches drip with fuzzy red "bottlebrushes" that are really clusters of stamens, not petals — and they are irresistible to hummingbirds, butterflies, and honeybees. Crush a narrow leaf and it gives off a clean lemon scent. The weeping silhouette makes it one of the park's most graceful small trees. An Australian native that thrives in Florida sun.

SIZE

15–20 ft tall & wide; weeping

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Flowers for tea



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Peregrina

Jatropha integerrima

A tireless bloomer, scattering star-shaped crimson flowers nearly year-round in frost-free spots and feeding butterflies and hummingbirds when little else is in flower. It is a cousin of the poinsettia, and like many in that family every part is dangerously toxic if eaten. Glossy, fiddle-shaped leaves and a tidy form make it a favorite landscape shrub. Easy and drought-tough.

SIZE

8–15 ft tall

TOXICITY

Deadly — all parts

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Peacock Flower

Caesalpinia pulcherrima

Fiery red-and-gold blooms with long, whisker-like stamens give this shrub its other name, dwarf poinciana. It is the national flower of Barbados, pictured on the country's coat of arms, and a close relative of the towering Royal Poinciana. A nonstop nectar source for butterflies and hummingbirds in warm months.

SIZE

6–10 ft

TOXICITY

Skin & eye irritant

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Immature seeds only



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Queen's Wreath

Petrea volubilis

The true flowers drop quickly, but their starry lavender calyces linger for weeks, creating the illusion of months-long bloom. A showy climbing vine from the West Indies and Mexico south to Panama. Draped over a trellis or arbor, it is pure tropical romance.

SIZE

Vine to 25–40 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought & salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Pentas

Pentas lanceolata

One of the most scientifically validated butterfly plants you can grow — studies show it draws more butterfly species and individuals than almost any other garden flower. Its shallow flower tubes welcome even short-tongued visitors. Clusters of starry blooms in red, pink, and white keep coming all season. An East African native and tireless pollinator magnet.

SIZE

3–4 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun

EDIBILITY

Not edible

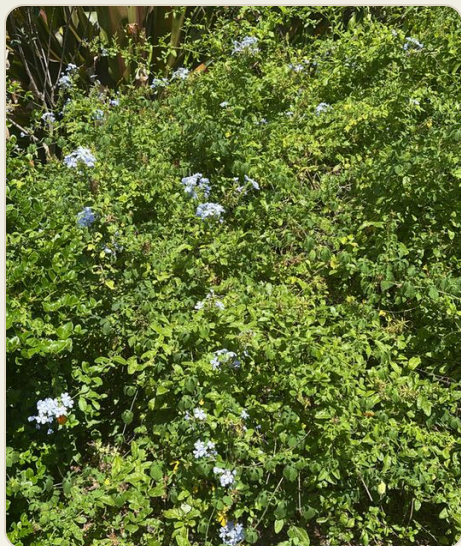


Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Plumbago

Plumbago auriculata

Its genuine sky-blue flowers are a rarity in nature, glowing against soft green foliage for much of the year. A sticky coating on the flower stems foils insects that would steal nectar without pollinating. Easygoing and heat-loving, this South African favorite has been a Florida garden staple for generations.

SIZE

4–8 ft

TOXICITY

Skin & eye irritant

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible

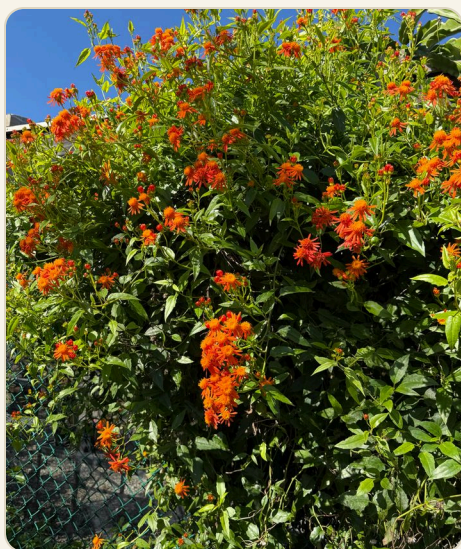


Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Mexican Flame Vine

Pseudogynoxys chenopodioides

A vigorous climber that smothers fences and trellises in clusters of glowing orange-red daisies, alive with butterflies. Formerly known as *Senecio confusus*, it has naturalized in some disturbed Florida areas, so it is worth keeping in bounds. Where managed, it adds bold, tropical heat to any vertical space.

SIZE

16–33 ft

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible

♦ Tropical Foliage & Accent Plants ♦

Bold leaves and architectural form — the green architecture of the park



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Copperleaf

Acalypha wilkesiana 'Java White'

Grown for its foliage rather than flowers, its large leaves are splashed in creamy white and green like living brushstrokes. The wider genus has a long history of traditional medicinal use across many cultures. Originating in the Pacific Islands, it brings bright, painterly color to shady corners.

SIZE

10–15 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

White Bird of Paradise

Strelitzia reginae

Bold, banana-like leaves and striking white-and-blue flowers made this South African native a design-magazine darling in the 1970s. It clumps into a dramatic, fan-shaped silhouette that can tower overhead. Architectural and unmistakable, it is instant tropical drama.

SIZE

20–30 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Giant Milkweed

Calotropis gigantea

The host plant for the plain tiger butterfly, with toxic sap that shields its caterpillars from predators — the same trick monarchs use. Thick, gray-green leaves set off clusters of waxy, star-shaped lavender flowers. A South Asian native, it is also a beloved fixture of Hawaiian gardens.

SIZE

6–12 ft

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Grandleaf Seagrape

Coccoloba pubescens

Its enormous leaves — up to three feet across, and even larger on young plants — make a bold tropical statement. It is a distinct cousin of Florida's familiar coastal seagrape, hailing from the Caribbean. Dramatic foliage and a sturdy, sculptural form make it a standout specimen.

SIZE

To 80 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought & salt tolerant

EDIBILITY

Fruit edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

African Iris

Dietes iridioides

Nicknamed the fortnight lily, it sends up fresh white-and-yellow blooms with clockwork regularity roughly every two weeks. Each flower lasts only a day, but a steady parade of new buds keeps the show going for months. Tough, evergreen, and endlessly tidy.

SIZE

2-4 ft

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

TOXICITY

Skin & eye irritant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Philodendron xanadu

Thaumatococcus xanadu

Its deeply lobed, glossy leaves give it the nickname "wonder leaf," fanning out in a neat, mounding clump. Recently reclassified out of Philodendron into a new genus, it remains a landscaping workhorse. Brazilian by origin, it is a lush, low-care anchor for shaded beds.

SIZE

2-4 ft

CONDITIONS

Part shade • Drought tolerant

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

EDIBILITY

Not edible

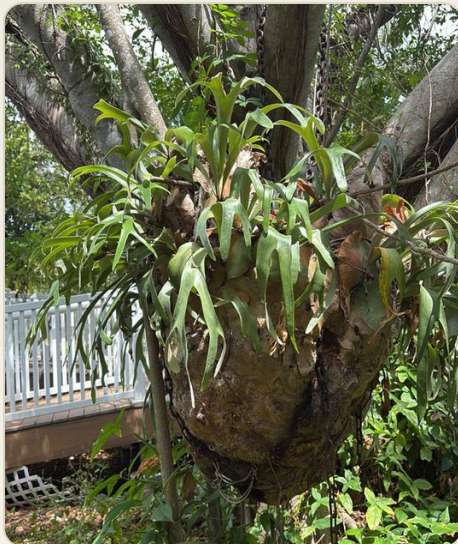


Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Staghorn Fern

Platycerium spp.

It grows sideways or even upside down on tree trunks and walls, anchored without any soil at all. Flat shield fronds catch falling debris and rainwater to feed the plant, while antler-like fronds give it its name. In its native Australian forests it can grow truly massive. A captivating epiphyte.

SIZE

2–6 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Indirect to filtered light

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Snake Plant

Sansevieria trifasciata

NASA air-quality studies put this tough succulent near the top for scrubbing indoor pollutants — and it keeps making oxygen at night, when most plants rest. Its stiff, upright leaves are banded like snakeskin, and it is famously nearly impossible to kill. A hardy survivor from West Africa.

SIZE

2–4 ft

TOXICITY

Skin & eye irritant

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Spath Lilly

Spathiphyllum spp.

Another NASA air-purifying star, prized for cleaning indoor air. Its pure white blooms symbolize peace and are a familiar sight at funerals. Happiest in shaded, moist spots, it is a serene, glossy-leaved native of tropical America.

SIZE

1–4 ft

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

CONDITIONS

Part shade • Moist to wet

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Parrots Beak

Heliconia psittacorum

Its curved, beak-like flowers are a textbook case of coevolution — shaped to match a hummingbird's bill exactly. One of the smallest and most popular heliconias, it forms tidy clumps of paddle-shaped leaves topped with fiery orange bracts. Compact, colorful, and reliably eye-catching.

SIZE

3–6 ft

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet

EDIBILITY

Not edible

Culturally & Historically Significant

Plants woven into the stories of people, place, and time



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Queen's Crepe Myrtle

Lagerstroemia speciosa

Summer brings huge trusses of crinkled pink-to-magenta blooms — far showier than the common crape myrtles most Floridians know. Across South and Southeast Asia it is prized less for its flowers than for medicine: the leaves carry corosolic acid, brewed as "banaba" tea to help lower blood sugar. Its timber is famously tough, ranked just behind teak. In Theravada Buddhist tradition the tree is linked to enlightenment.

SIZE

30–60 ft tall × 30–40 ft wide

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moderately drought & salt tolerant

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

EDIBILITY

Medicinal tea



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Century Plant

Agave americana

One of nature's most dramatic finales: after 10 to 30 unhurried years, a single giant stalk rockets up 20 feet or more — sometimes a foot a day — blooms once in a spectacular crown, then the plant dies, leaving offshoots to carry on. The name oversells it — decades, not centuries — but the spectacle earns the legend. Across Mexico the maguey was used for everything: rope fiber, fermented pulque, and the roasted heart for food.

SIZE

6–10 ft rosette; stalk to 20–25 ft

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Exceptional drought & salt tolerance

TOXICITY

Skin irritant & spines

EDIBILITY

Roasted heart edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Canna Lily

Canna indica

Cultivated so long — possibly 4,000 years — that its true wild origin is now uncertain. Across tropical America, Indigenous peoples used the starchy rhizomes for food, the hard seeds as beads and rattles, and the leaves for wrapping and cooking. Today's flashy ornamental cultivars barely resemble their wild ancestors, but the cultural story runs deep.

SIZE

3–6 ft

TOXICITY

Toxic if eaten

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet

EDIBILITY

Rhizomes (historic)

Plants to Watch & Invasive Awareness

Know these plants — some charm, some escape, some conquer



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Mexican Petunia

Ruellia simplex

INVASIVE

Delicate purple flowers open each morning and drop by afternoon — lovely in isolation, but this plant simply does not know when to stop. A Category I invasive in Florida since 2001, it spreads aggressively by seeds that burst from their pods, overrunning roadsides, wetlands, and wild areas. Worth knowing on sight so you can keep it from escaping its bed.

SIZE

3–4 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Umbrella Tree

Schefflera actinophylla

INVASIVE

A spectacular foliage plant in a controlled setting — but it has earned its place in this section. Native to Australia and New Guinea, it spreads aggressively in South Florida by bird-dropped seeds, colonizing native hammocks and tree canopies, and its roots can damage structures. Admire the dramatic leaves, but do not plant it — and pull seedlings when you find them.

SIZE

To 40 ft

TOXICITY

Skin & eye irritant

CONDITIONS

Part shade • Drought tolerant

EDIBILITY

Not edible



Photo: iNaturalist contributor

Fakahatchee Grass

Tripsacum dactyloides

FLORIDA NATIVE

A true Florida native with a misleadingly exotic look — it belongs here completely. This bold, clumping grass grows wild in wetlands and disturbed ground statewide, and was historically important to wildlife and Indigenous peoples for forage and weaving. Tough, architectural, and underappreciated — proof that not every dramatic grass is an invader.

SIZE

4–8 ft

TOXICITY

Non-toxic

CONDITIONS

Full sun • Moist to wet

EDIBILITY

Seeds (historic)

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With gratitude to the volunteers behind the lens

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Photographer credits

[Photographer names to be added — match each plant to its iNaturalist observer.]

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